

Qualifying & Diagnosing (The Question Stack)

Top closers don't pitch — they diagnose. The exact 10-question stack that uncovers the REAL problem and builds the case for change.

READ TIME

9 min read

LEVEL

Critical

LESSON

06 / 14

The Diagnostic Method

Doctors don't sell surgery — they diagnose conditions and prescribe treatments. **You're doing the same thing.** Discovery isn't about gathering information for YOUR pitch — it's about making THEM see their problem clearly enough that the solution becomes obvious.

THE MENTAL MODEL

Imagine a doctor who walks in and immediately says 'You need knee surgery, here's the price.' You'd run. Now imagine the same doctor asking 'When did it start?' 'Does it hurt more when standing?' 'Show me where exactly?' By the time they suggest surgery, you're begging for it. THAT'S sales.

→ The 10-Question Discovery Stack

These questions are sequenced intentionally — each one builds on the last. **Follow them in order.**

Q 1

Business Context (3-4 min)

'Walk me through your business — what do you do, how long have you been at it, what's the current setup look like?'

Let them talk uninterrupted. Take notes. They'll naturally share clues about pain, ambition, history.

Q 2

Current Numbers

'What does an average month look like for you in terms of revenue and lead flow?'

Get specifics. Numbers. Don't accept 'good' or 'okay.' Push: 'Roughly what's your monthly revenue right now?'

Q 3

Current Lead Sources

'Walk me through how you're currently getting clients — what's working, what's not?'

Tells you what to AVOID pitching against and what to position yourself NEXT to (not vs).

Q 4

Best Month Ever

'What was your best month ever — and what was different about it?'

Reveals their ceiling potential. Often the answer is 'when X channel was working' or 'when I had a big project.' Tells you what they're capable of.

Q 5

Goals (Stretch)

'Where do you want to be in 90 days from now? And what about 12 months from now?'

Establishes the GAP between current state and desired state. Bigger gap = bigger need.

Q 6

The Gap Question

'So you're at [current] and you want to be at [goal] — what do you think is the biggest thing in the way?'

THE most important question. Their answer is the OBJECTION they'll raise later. Address it now in advance.

Q 7

Past Attempts

'What have you tried to fix this so far?'

Tells you (a) what NOT to pitch (they've already failed at it), (b) their sophistication level, (c) what 'won't work' objections they'll have.

Q 8

Cost Of Inaction

'If nothing changes — same lead flow, same revenue — over the next 6 months, what does that look like for your business?'

Makes them feel the pain of STAYING THE SAME. Pain motivates action 3x more than gain. Sit in silence after asking this.

Q 9

Decision Process

'Before we get into solutions — are you the sole decision-maker on something like this, or is there a partner/spouse you'd want to loop in?'

Critical to ask BEFORE pitching. If they say 'I need to talk to my partner,' that's information to address NOW.

Q 10

Budget Sensitivity

'And in terms of investment — what kind of monthly marketing budget are you working with currently or willing to invest in something that works?'

Find out if you're in range. If they say £500, you know your £2k offer needs different framing OR they're not a fit.

→ How To Ask Questions (The Delivery)

RULE 1

Use Their Words

If they say 'I want more jobs,' don't say 'so you want more revenue.' Say 'so you want more jobs.' Mirror their exact language back. Shows you're listening.

RULE 2

Stack Follow-Ups

Don't just ask Q1 and move to Q2. Stack: 'Walk me through your business.' [They answer.] 'Interesting — when you say you do residential roofing, what's the average ticket size?' [They answer.] 'Got it — and most of those coming from referrals or marketing?' Three layers deep = real understanding.

RULE 3

Strategic Silence

After asking the hard questions (Q6, Q8) — SHUT UP. Let them think. The silence is powerful. They'll fill it with more honesty than they intended to share.

RULE 4

Mirroring

When they say something important, REPEAT IT BACK as a question. 'So your show rate is around 30%?' (with rising tone). They'll elaborate. Free information.

RULE 5

Labels

Validate what they're feeling. 'It sounds like the unpredictability is what's most frustrating, right?' Makes them feel deeply understood. Builds trust faster than anything.

→ What You're LISTENING For

DIAGNOSTIC SIGNALS

- ✓ Specific numbers (revenue, leads, cost) — for tying to your offer
- ✓ Emotional language ('frustrated,' 'stuck,' 'exhausted') — pain signals
- ✓ Past attempts that failed — what NOT to pitch

- ✓ Ambition signals ('I want to scale to £100k') — goals to anchor to
- ✓ Decision-maker language ('I,' 'we,' 'my partner') — sales dynamics
- ✓ Time pressure ('I need this fixed by spring') — urgency leverage
- ✓ Objections they hint at ('I've been burned before') — preempt these

→ The Diagnostic Summary

Before pitching, summarise what you've heard. This proves you listened and creates a yes-momentum:

PRE-PITCH SUMMARY SCRIPT

YOU: *Okay, just to make sure I've got this right —*

YOU: *You're doing about £18K/month in roofing in Houston. You've been at it 8 years with a 14-person team. You're getting most leads from referrals which is unpredictable, and you've tried Google Ads but they haven't worked well. You want to get to £40K/month in the next 6 months but the inconsistent lead flow is the biggest blocker. Is that fair?*

PROSPECT: *Yeah, exactly.*

YOU: *Cool. So based on that — I think I can help. Want me to walk you through how this would work?*

WHY THE SUMMARY WORKS

It (1) proves you listened, (2) makes them confirm 'yes' before the pitch — creating a yes-momentum, (3) frames their problem in YOUR terms (so the solution feels natural), (4) creates pre-conviction in the pitch.

→ Common Diagnostic Mistakes

BEGINNER MISTAKES

- Asking 3 questions and pitching
- Asking generic questions
- Interrupting their answers
- Skipping uncomfortable questions
- Pitching while they're talking
- No summary before pitch

TOP CLOSER HABITS

- 10+ deep questions before pitch
- Specific, situational questions
- Strategic silence + note-taking
- Asking the hard ones (cost of inaction)
- Listening 80%, talking 20%
- Summary that locks in 'yes'

→ Tracking Discovery Quality

DISCOVERY DURATION TARGET	THEIR TALK TIME	QUESTIONS ASKED	SPECIFIC NUMBERS GATHERED
--	--	--	--

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Print The 10 Questions. Use Them On Your Next Call.

Don't try to memorise yet. PRINT this list. Have it in front of you on the next call. Ask each question. Take notes. Summary before pitch. After 5 calls following this script religiously, it becomes natural.

END OF LESSON 06

Diagnosis = Done.

Now the pitch — exactly how to present your solution so it lands as the obvious answer.

NEXT → THE PITCH STRUCTURE